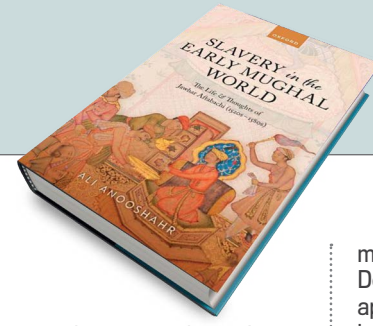
M ZHAZO



ABSOLUTE JAFAR
Sarnath Banerjee
HarperCollins India/ Fiction

Comics fans will be delighted with this new work of graphic fiction from one of India's pioneering comics artists, Sarnath Banerjee. *Absolute Jafar* is the most personal narrative Banerjee has written and drawn so far, the story of an Indo-Pak marriage unravelling and a child becoming "a geopolitical oddity" for no fault of his own. All of this against the backdrop of labyrinthine bureaucracies and immutable national borders.



THE HIMALAYA IN TWELVE PIECES
Anuradha Roy
Hachette India/ Non-fiction

Anuradha Roy is the Booker-shortlisted author of novels like *Sleeping on Jupiter* and *The Folded Earth*. This book is the true story of how Anuradha and her husband Rukun found a decrepit cottage in the Himalayas and renovated it until it was unrecognisable. Remarkably, they go on to craft new lives in the hills at the cottage. Roy's book is about this sequence of events but more importantly, it is about the Himalayas themselves; the ecology, the pace of life, the boundless, endangered beauty.



RAJWANT RAWAT

MELANIN
Jeet Thayil
HarperCollins India/ Fiction

Jeet Thayil's novel *Narcopolis* was nominated for a bunch of awards around the world, and won him hordes of new readers. His new novel *Melanin* sees Thayil in experimental mode, with the narrative often jumping time zones and continents without much warning. This book straddles the line between memoir and fiction, prose and poetry and is also deeply informed by photography. Read it to discover what new tricks Thayil has up his sleeve.

GREAT EASTERN HOTEL
Ruchir Joshi
HarperCollins India/ Fiction

Ruchir Joshi's debut novel *The Last Jet-Engine Laugh* (2001) marked him as a unique, exuberant new voice in 21st century Indian literature. Over two decades after his debut comes *Great Eastern Hotel*, a 1,000-page doorstopper set in Calcutta during the onset of the Second World War. Famine, war, rebellion and a clash of cultures—Joshi's long-awaited sophomore novel takes on the conventional Big Themes in literature. Could this be India's next massive, internationally influential work of literary fiction?

SLAVERY IN THE EARLY MUGHAL WORLD
Ali Anooshahr
Oxford University Press/ Non-fiction

This book examines Jawahar Aftabachi's memoir *Tazkirah-i-Vaqi'at* as a springboard to examine slavery and the early, interconnected world of the Indian Ocean. Enslaved by the Ottomans in the early 16th century, Aftabachi sails around the world before landing up as a slave at the Mughal emperor Humayun's court, acting as Humayun's water-bearer. This unique subaltern point of view from within the Mughal set-up in the 16th century is important and Anooshahr does a fine job of condensing the memoir's many digressions and sideshows into a coherent, historically valuable document.

GODDESS COMPLEX
Sanjena Sathian
Penguin Random House/ Fiction

Sanjana Satyananda, having recently dumped her actor husband at an Indian commune after a conversation about having children, is struggling to piece together her life again. Her too-perfect sister is proving to be insufferable on a daily basis, her anthropology dissertation is incomplete and her friends barely have a second in between mortgages, marriages and other assorted 'adulting' paraphernalia. Can Sanjana finalise her divorce and get her life back on track? A bittersweet new novel from the acclaimed author of *Gold Diggers*.

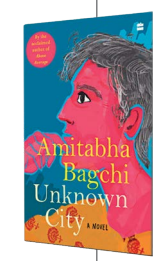


THE LIVER DOCTOR
Dr Cyriac Abby Philips
HarperCollins India/ Non-fiction

Dr Cyriac Abby Philips is better known by his social media moniker, 'The Liver Doctor'. His blunt, forthright approach to medical advice has won him a dedicated fanbase and he has been ruthless in his fact-checks on pseudo-science peddled by online influencers. For the first time ever, Dr Philips tells us the story of his career, both online and offline, and how he had to develop a thick skin in order to function as a hardnosed rationalist in contemporary India.

UNKNOWN CITY
Amitabha Bagchi
HarperCollins India/ Fiction

Amitabha Bagchi returns to Arindam Chatterjee, the protagonist of his bestselling debut novel *Above Average* (2007). Arindam, now 50, has returned to India after a string of failed relationships. He looks back at the women in his life. Through these recollections, Arindam tries to make sense of his own masculinity and how it has evolved down the years. A much-anticipated follow-up by one of Indian English literature's most distinctive and accomplished voices.



A PICTURE OF ARYAN PASHA:
The Girl Who Never Was
Apra Kuchal
HarperCollins India/ Non-fiction

This is the biography of Aryan Pasha, assigned female at birth but who went on to become India's first competitive trans man bodybuilder. Kuchal tells the story of Pasha's triumphs against all odds to achieve his fondest dream. A must-read at a time of great churn internationally, when trans athletes are being viewed with suspicion.

–Aditya Mani Jha